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Herod Antipas

The ruler of Galilee who beheaded John the Baptist and mocked Jesus.

Herod Antipas, a son of Herod the Great, ruled Galilee and Perea for more than forty years, the region where Jesus grew up and did most of his ministry. The Gospels show a man pulled in two directions. He feared John the Baptist and liked to hear him, yet imprisoned him for condemning his marriage and beheaded him to keep a rash oath. He wanted to see Jesus do a miracle, yet when Jesus stood before him, Herod mocked him. Jesus called him "that fox." His life shows how curiosity about God can harden into contempt.

At a glance

Name	Herod Antipas, "Herod the tetrarch" (Luke 3:19)
Family	Son of Herod the Great; brother of Archelaus (Matthew 2:22)
Office	Tetrarch of Galilee and Perea, 4 BC–AD 39
Wife	Herodias, formerly his brother's wife (Mark 6:17)
Cities	Rebuilt Sepphoris; founded Tiberias
Key people	John the Baptist, Herodias, Jesus, Pontius Pilate
Main passages	Mark 6:14–29; Luke 3:19–20; 9:7–9; 13:31–33; 23:6–12
Jesus called him	"That fox" (Luke 13:32)

"And when Herod saw Jesus, he was exceeding glad: for he was desirous to see him of a long season, because he had heard many things of him; and he hoped to have seen some miracle done by him."

Luke 23:8, KJV

The life of Herod Antipas

Dates are approximate. His reign and exile come from Josephus. Gospel events follow the house chronology, with the crucifixion c. AD 30; on the other main view (AD 33), add about three years.

c. 4 BC

*After his
father's death*

● **Becomes tetrarch**

When Herod the Great dies, Rome divides his kingdom among his sons. Antipas receives Galilee and Perea. Luke later dates John's ministry by him: "Herod being tetrarch of Galilee." *Luke 3:1*

c. AD 28–29

Galilee

● **Imprisons John**

John rebukes Herod for taking Herodias, his brother's wife, "and for all the evils which Herod had done." Herod shuts John up in prison. *Luke 3:19–20; Mark 6:17–18*

c. AD 29

His birthday

● **Beheads John**

At a birthday feast Herodias' daughter dances, and Herod swears to give her whatever she asks. Prompted by her mother, she asks for John's head. Herod, "exceeding sorry," sends an executioner. *Mark 6:21–28*

c. AD 29

Galilee

● **Troubled by Jesus**

Hearing of Jesus' works, Herod is perplexed. He says, "It is John, whom I beheaded: he is risen from the dead," and he wants to see Jesus. *Mark 6:14–16; Luke 9:7–9*

c. AD 29–30

On the road

● **Threatens Jesus**

Some Pharisees warn Jesus that Herod wants to kill him. Jesus replies, "Go ye, and tell that fox," and continues his work on the way to Jerusalem. *Luke 13:31–33*

c. AD 30

Crucifixion day

● **Mocks Jesus**

Pilate sends Jesus to Herod, who is in Jerusalem. Herod questions him at length, but Jesus answers nothing. Herod and his soldiers mock him, dress him in a gorgeous robe, and send him back. *Luke 23:6–12*

Key activities

Mark 6:17 calls Herodias's first husband Philip, while Josephus calls him Herod. Many think he had both names, and he is not the same as Philip the tetrarch of Luke 3:1. Herodias's daughter is not named in Scripture; Josephus names her Salome.

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- 1 **Ruled Galilee.** He governed the region where Jesus lived and ministered. *Luke 3:1; 23:6-7*
 - 2 **Took his brother's wife.** He married Herodias, which John said was not lawful. *Mark 6:17-18*
 - 3 **Listened to John.** He feared John as a just and holy man and heard him gladly, yet did not change. *Mark 6:20*
 - 4 **Kept a foolish oath.** Rather than lose face before his guests, he kept a rash promise. *Mark 6:22-26*
 - 5 **Killed John.** He had John beheaded in prison, and John's disciples buried the body. *Mark 6:27-29*
 - 6 **Wanted to see Jesus.** He was curious and hoped to see a miracle. *Luke 9:9; 23:8*
 - 7 **Mocked the silent Jesus.** When Jesus would not answer, Herod set him at nought and mocked him. *Luke 23:9-11*
 - 8 **Made friends with Pilate.** That same day he and Pilate, once enemies, became friends. *Luke 23:12*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Herod Antipas.

Old Testament

Leviticus 18:16; 20:21	No taking a brother's wife, behind John's rebuke
Psalms 2:1-2	Applied to Herod and Pilate (Acts 4:25-27)
Echo: 1 Kings 19:1-2; 21:17-24	Ahab and Jezebel against the prophet Elijah
Echo: Esther 5:3	A king offers "to the half of the kingdom" (Mark 6:23)

New Testament

Matthew 14:1-12; Mark 6:14-29	The death of John the Baptist
Luke 3:1, 19-20; 9:7-9; 13:31-33; 23:6-12	Luke's fuller portrait
Luke 8:3; Acts 13:1	Joanna, wife of his steward, and Manaen, raised with him
Acts 4:27	Named among those gathered against Jesus
Mark 8:15	"The leaven of Herod"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Herod think of John, according to Mark 6:20?
2. *Understand:* Herod liked to hear John but would not change. Why is that so dangerous?
3. *Apply:* Herod kept a rash promise to save face. Is there a promise you should rethink, or be slower to make?
4. *Apply:* Herod wanted a miracle, not a Master. How can you come to Jesus this week for who he is, not only what he can do?